

Chapter 5 — Kingdoms, Kings and an Early Republic

The 16 Mahajanapadas and the Rise of Magadha

The one-line point: Tribes (*jana*) turn into territories (*janapada*), then into 16 big states (*mahajanapadas*), which fight it out until **Magadha** wins everything. This chapter is the birth of the **state** in India — taxes, standing armies, fortified capitals — and it contains India's first **republics**.

← Ch.4 | Index | Next: Ch.6 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Ancient India
Sub-discipline	Early Historic Period — the Second Urbanisation ; state formation
Period	~600 BCE – 321 BCE (the "Mahajanapada era")
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → Mahajanapadas, Magadhan expansion, ganas/sanghas
Mains (GS Paper I)	Weak directly; feeds <i>state formation</i> , and Polity answers on ancient republican traditions
Also feeds	Polity ★ (ganas/sanghas as India's indigenous republican tradition — a favourite for "India's democratic roots"), Geography (why Magadha's location won), Economy (taxation origins)
Weightage	★★★★ — 1–2 Prelims Qs typical. The 16 Mahajanapadas + capitals is a standard matching question
Overlaps with	Ch.6 (Buddha and Mahavira live in exactly this world), Ch.7 (Magadha becomes the Mauryan Empire)

 **Ancient India** → **Early Historic**. The genuinely valuable crossover is into **Polity**: the *gana-sangha* is the stock example whenever an answer needs "India's own republican tradition predates Western democracy."

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** the progression *jana* → *janapada* → *mahajanapada*, and what each word literally means.
- ☐ **Name** the 16 Mahajanapadas and match at least the major ones to their capitals.
- ☐ **Describe** the **Ashvamedha** and explain what it was politically *for*.
- ☐ **List** the four features that distinguish a mahajanapada from a Rigvedic *jana* (fortification, standing army, regular taxation, permanent capital).
- ☐ **State** the tax rates and types: *bhaga* (1/6), *bali*, *kara*, *vishti*, and taxes on craftspersons, herders, traders and hunters.
- ☐ **Explain** the four reasons Magadha won — and rank them.
- ☐ **Sequence** Magadha's rulers: Bimbisara → Ajatasattu → Shishunaga → Mahapadma Nanda → (Chandragupta Maurya).
- ☐ **Describe** the *gana/sangha* system using **Vajji** as the case study, and state honestly who was excluded.

- ☐ **Explain** who **Panini** was and why the *Ashtadhyayi* matters.
- ☐ **Describe** Alexander's invasion and its actual (limited) consequences.
- ☐ **Argue** whether the gana-sanghas were "democracies" — with the correct caveats.

Start Here: The Word That Explains Everything

Chapter 4 left you with *jana* — **people**, a tribe with no fixed territory.

Now watch one word do all the work:

<u>JANA</u>	<u>JANAPADA</u>	<u>MAHAJANAPADA</u>
"the PEOPLE"	jana + PADA (pada = FOOT)	MAHA + janapada (maha = GREAT)
A tribe. Mobile. Wealth = cattle. No territory.	"The land where the people set their FOOT" → TERRITORY! → You now belong to a PLACE, not just a group. → Land can be owned, defended, TAXED.	A BIG janapada that swallowed its neighbours. → 16 of them. → Fortified capitals, standing armies, regular taxes. → THE STATE IS BORN.

 **The instant land matters more than cattle, everything changes.** You can't tax a herd that walks away. You *can* tax a field. Fixed territory makes permanent revenue possible, permanent revenue funds a standing army, and a standing army makes the territory permanent. **That loop is the state.**

Why did land suddenly matter? Chapter 4 gave you the answer: **IRON**. Iron axes cleared the dense Ganga forests; iron ploughshares broke heavy alluvial soil; paddy **transplantation** multiplied yields. Suddenly a fixed piece of Ganga-valley land produced a **massive, reliable surplus** — worth owning, worth defending, worth taxing.

The Software Engineer's Analogy

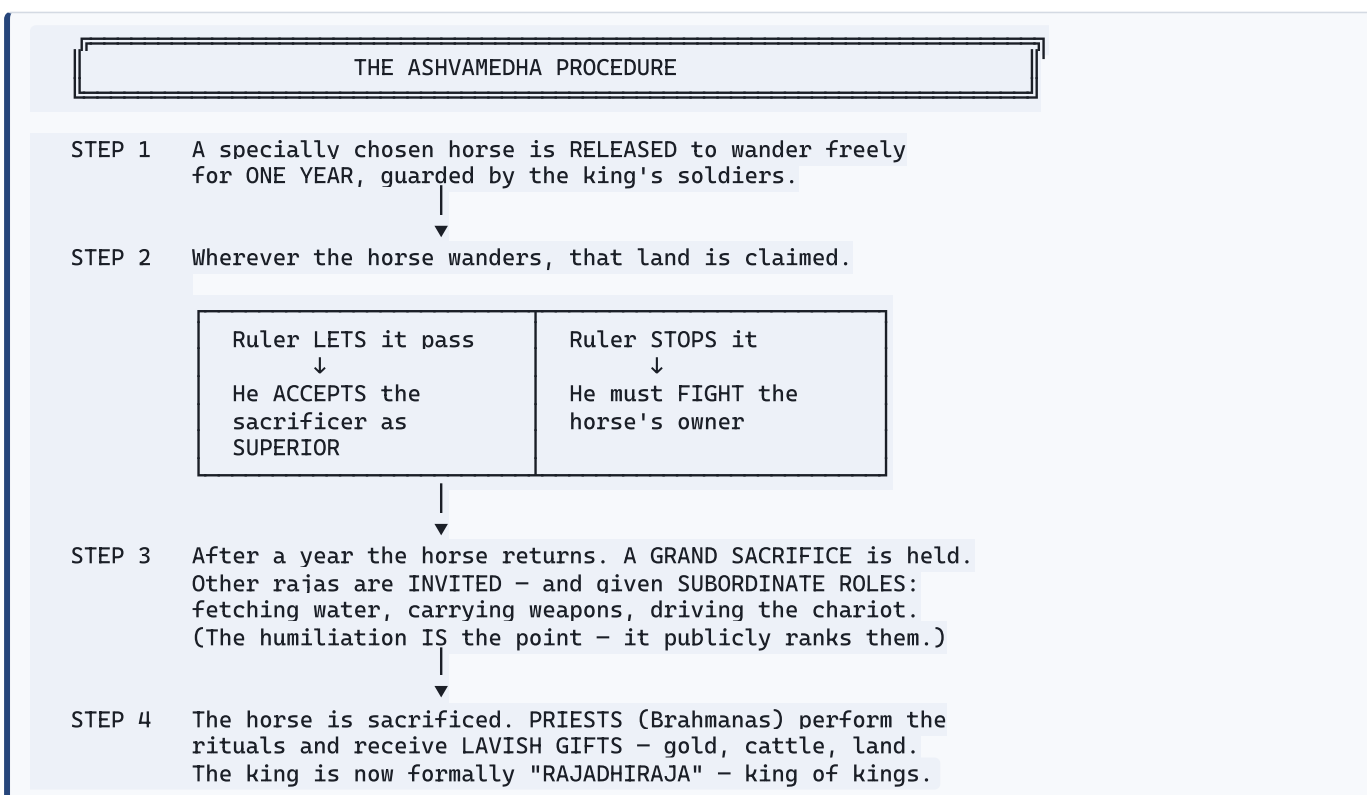
RIGVEDIC JANA	→	MAHAJANAPADA
Ad-hoc peer network	→	Managed cluster with a control plane
Leader by acclamation	→	Permanent authoritative node (the king)
Voluntary contributions (bali – a tip)	→	MANDATORY, METERED BILLING (tax) (bhaga – 1/6, assessed and collected)
Militia, disbanded after the raid	→	Standing army (always-on service, paid from the revenue pool)
No boundary	→	Fortified perimeter (the wall = firewall)
No persistent capital	→	A capital = the primary datacentre
— AND THE OTHER MODEL —		
GANA / SANGHA:	consensus among a set of designated nodes. No single leader; decisions by discussion and vote. Robust to losing any one node – but SLOW, and it lost to the monarchies precisely because consensus is slower than command under war pressure.	

🎯 **That last line is a genuinely good Mains point:** the gana-sanghas were absorbed by monarchies not because they were worse at governing, but because **deliberation is slower than command in a period of continuous warfare**. The same tension appears in every discussion of democratic decision-making under crisis.

1 How a Man Became a King: The Ashvamedha

In the Rigveda the *raja* was chosen. In the Later Vedic period, kings needed something stronger — **ritual legitimacy**. Enter the great sacrifices.

🐎 The Ashvamedha (Horse Sacrifice) — the big one



🖥️ **The Ashvamedha is a distributed consensus protocol for establishing hierarchy.** The horse is a probe packet broadcast across the network. Every node must respond: acknowledge (submit) or reject (fight). After one year you have a complete, publicly-witnessed map of who accepts your authority. **The ritual doesn't just declare supremacy — it tests and records it.** That's why it was worth a year and a fortune.

The political economy of it: the sacrifice was ruinously expensive. Who benefited?

- **The king** — legitimacy, and a public ranking of rivals
- **The Brahmanas** — enormous gifts, and confirmation that only *they* could confer kingship
- **A mutually reinforcing bargain:** the king gets divine sanction, the priest gets wealth and indispensability

Other great sacrifices to know:

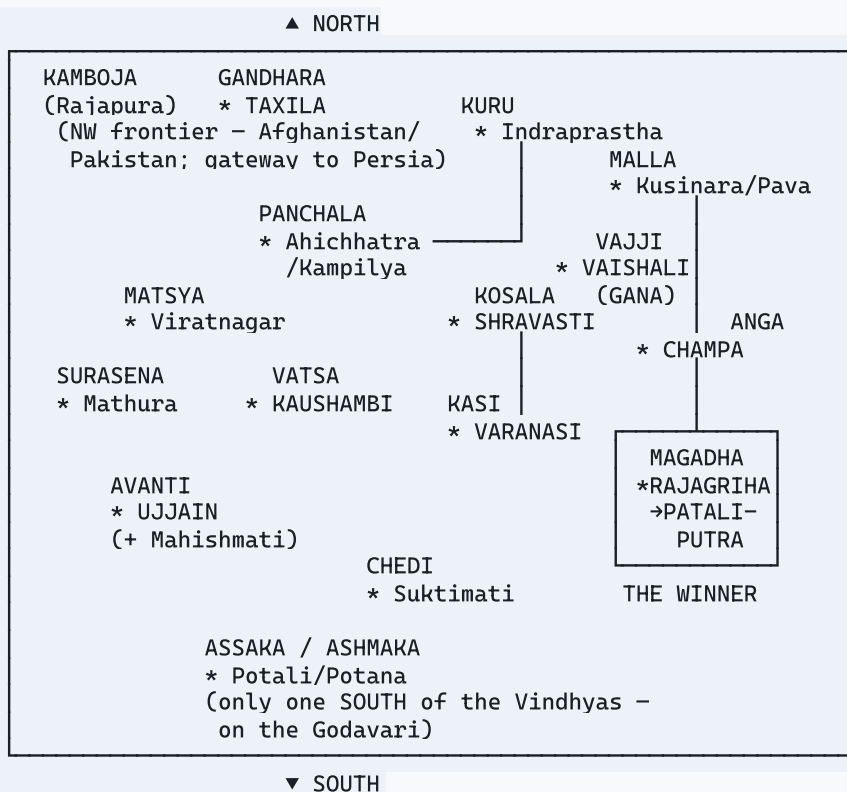
Sacrifice	Purpose
Rajasuya	Royal consecration — the coronation ritual
Vajapeya	A chariot race the king was arranged to win; conferred supremacy
Ashvamedha	Horse sacrifice asserting paramouncy over neighbours

🎯 **Who else could attend?** *Vaishyas* (called *vis*, the ordinary people) brought gifts. **Shudras** and others were **excluded** from these rituals — the sacrifice was also a machine for enacting the varna hierarchy in public.

2 The Sixteen Mahajanapadas

By ~600 BCE, Buddhist and Jaina texts (especially the *Anguttara Nikaya*) list **sixteen** great states. **Match these to capitals — it's a standard question.**

THE 16 MAHAJANAPADAS – SCHEMATIC MAP (~600 BCE)



The full list with capitals

#	Mahajanapada	Capital	Modern region	Note
1	Magadha ★★ ★	Rajagriha (Girivraja) → later Pataliputra	South Bihar	The eventual winner
2	Kosala ★ ★	Shravasti (also Ayodhya, Saketa)	Eastern UP	Rival of Magadha; Buddha's home region
3	Vatsa ★	Kaushambi	Around Allahabad, UP	King Udayana
4	Avanti ★ ★	Ujjain (north) / Mahishmati (south)	Malwa, MP	Powerful; Ujjain is a key city
5	Vajji / Vrijji ★ ★ ★	Vaishali	North Bihar	★ A GANA / SANGHA (republic)
6	Malla ★	Kusinara and Pava	UP/Bihar border	★ Also a gana ; Buddha died at Kusinara
7	Kasi ★	Varanasi	Eastern UP	Absorbed by Kosala
8	Anga ★	Champa	East Bihar/Bengal	Annexed by Bimbisara of Magadha
9	Kuru	Indraprastha (Hastinapura)	Delhi/Haryana	Mahabharata heartland
10	Panchala	Ahichhatra (N) & Kampilya (S)	Western UP	
11	Matsya	Viratnagar	Rajasthan (Alwar)	
12	Surasena ★	Mathura	Western UP	Krishna tradition; later a great trade city (Ch.8)
13	Chedi	Suktimati / Sotthivati	Bundelkhand	
14	Gandhara ★ ★	Taxila (Takshashila)	NW Pakistan/Afghanistan	★ Great learning centre ; gateway to Persia; Panini worked here
15	Kamboja ★	Rajapura	Afghanistan/Kashmir borderlands	Famous for horses ; also a gana
16	Assaka / Ashmaka ★	Potali / Potana	On the Godavari	★ The ONLY mahajanapada south of the Vindhyas

🧠 Memory anchors that carry most of the marks:

- **Magadha** → **Rajagriha**, then **Pataliputra** (this shift matters — Ch.7)
- **Kosala** → **Shravasti** | **Vatsa** → **Kaushambi** | **Avanti** → **Ujjain**
- **Vajji** → **Vaishali** (the **republic**) | **Gandhara** → **Taxila** (learning) | **Kasi** → **Varanasi**
- **Assaka** = the lone southern one, on the **Godavari**
- **Anga** = first conquest of Bimbisara

🏰 What made a mahajanapada different — four features

Feature	Detail
1. FORTIFIED CAPITAL	Massive walls of wood, brick or stone. Rajagriha was ringed by hills <i>and</i> walls; Kaushambi and Ujjain had huge mud ramparts
2. STANDING ARMY	Permanent, paid soldiers — not a militia raised per raid. Soldiers were paid regularly and some were given tokens (coins)
3. REGULAR TAXATION	Systematic, assessed, compulsory. This is the decisive break from the Rigvedic <i>bali</i>.
4. OFFICIALS	Bureaucrats to assess, collect, store and account for revenue

Why fortify?

1. Fear of attack from other kings
2. Display of power and wealth — a wall is propaganda in brick
3. To **control everything and everyone inside** — a wall regulates who and what enters, which makes taxing trade possible

📖 **Notice the third reason.** A city wall isn't only defensive — it's an **ingress controller**. Everything entering passes a checkpoint, which is where you meter and bill it. Fortification is fiscal infrastructure disguised as military infrastructure.

3 Taxation — The Real Birth of the State

Learn these rates and categories; they're directly asked.

Payer	Tax	Rate/Form
Farmers (the main source) ★	BHAGA ("a share")	ONE-SIXTH (1/6) of the produce — hence the king was called <i>shadbhagin</i> ("taker of a sixth") ★
Craftspersons ★	VISHTI (forced labour)	Labour for one day every month for the king — no wages
Herders	Tax in kind	Animals and animal produce
Traders	Tax	On goods bought and sold
Hunters & gatherers	Tax in kind	Forest produce

★ **BHAGA = 1/6 of produce** and ***shadbhagin*** are the two highest-frequency facts in this section.

Why did farmers bear the main burden? Because iron tools plus new farming techniques made agriculture the largest, most reliable source of surplus. Two innovations mattered:

1. **The iron ploughshare** — turned over heavy, clayey alluvial soil that a wooden plough couldn't break
2. **Paddy transplantation** ★ — instead of scattering seed, saplings are grown in a nursery and **transplanted** into flooded fields. Far higher yields — **but hugely labour-intensive**. That labour was largely done by **dasas** (slaves) and **kammakaras** (landless labourers)

⚠️ **NCERT's quiet, important point:** the agricultural revolution that funded the state was powered by the **most exploited people in it**. Transplantation is backbreaking work done standing in water, and the people doing it were the ones with no land and no share of the surplus. **This is the inequality thread from the index, in its sharpest form. Use it in Mains.**

4 🏰 **MAGADHA — Why It Won Everything**

Out of sixteen states, one ended up ruling nearly all of India. **This is a question of causes, and UPSC likes causal questions.**

WHY MAGADHA WON – FOUR ADVANTAGES

- 1 **IRON ORE *******
The richest iron deposits in the subcontinent lay in south Bihar (Rajgir/Chotanagpur region) – right on Magadha's doorstep.
→ BEST WEAPONS + BEST AGRICULTURAL TOOLS.
Rivals had to import iron. Magadha mined it.
- 2 **ELEPHANT FORESTS *******
Dense forests supplied ELEPHANTS – the "tanks" of ancient warfare. An elephant could smash gates and break formations. Other states had horses; Magadha had elephants AND horses.
→ Forests also gave TIMBER for forts, houses and boats.
- 3 **RIVERS: GANGA + SON *******
 - Cheap TRANSPORT for goods and troops
 - CONTROL OF TRADE on the Ganga = customs revenue
 - Fertile alluvial floodplain = huge agricultural surplus
 - Rivers as NATURAL DEFENCE
- 4 **TWO SUPERB CAPITALS *******
RAJAGRIHA – "house of the king"; ringed by FIVE HILLS, plus massive stone walls. Nearly unassailable.
PATALIPUTRA – shifted here by Udayin; sits at the CONFLUENCE of the Ganga, Son, Gandak and Punpun.
Water on multiple sides = natural moat + total control of river traffic.

🎯 **If asked to rank them:** the resource endowment (iron + elephants) is primary — it's what rivals *could not replicate*. The rivers and capitals are force multipliers. Ambitious rulers (below) supplied the will.
Geography loaded the gun; the kings pulled the trigger.

The rulers of Magadha — get this sequence right

Ruler	Dynasty	Achievement
Bimbisara ★★	Haryanka	Annexed Anga ; used matrimonial alliances (married princesses of Kosala, Vaishali and Madra); contemporary of Buddha and Mahavira
Ajatasattu (Ajatashatru) ★★	Haryanka	Killed his father Bimbisara; destroyed the Vajji confederacy (using the minister Vassakara to sow internal discord ★); used war engines — the rathamusala (scythed chariot) and mahashilakantaka (stone-hurling catapult)
Udayin ★	Haryanka	Shifted the capital to PATALIPUTRA
Shishunaga	Shishunaga	Destroyed the power of Avanti — Magadha's last serious rival
Mahapadma Nanda ★★	Nanda	Greatly expanded the empire; enormous army; described as of humble origin. The Nandas' huge army reportedly deterred Alexander's troops
Dhana Nanda	Nanda	The last Nanda; unpopular due to heavy taxation; overthrown by Chandragupta Maurya (~321 BCE) → Chapter 7

🧠 **Sequence hook: "Bi-A-U-SH-N"** → **Bimbisara** → **Ajatasattu** → **Udayin** → **Shishunaga** → **Nandas** → (then Mauryas).

🎯 **The Vassakara story is a favourite.** Ajatasattu could not defeat the Vajji confederacy militarily, so he sent his minister Vassakara to Vaishali to **sow dissension among its leaders over three years**. Once unity broke, Vajji fell. **The moral NCERT draws:** the gana's strength *was* its unity, and its unity was its vulnerability. A neat, quotable illustration for answers on federalism, coalitions, or why deliberative bodies are vulnerable to internal division.

5 📁 The Ganas and Sanghas — India's Early Republics

This is the most exciting idea in the chapter, and the most useful outside History.

Not every mahajanapada was a monarchy. Some were **ganas** or **sanghas** — states ruled by an **assembly of many rulers**, not one king.

Aspect	Detail
The words	Gana = a group with many members. Sangha = an organisation/assembly. Together: "rule by the many"
Who ruled	Each of the many rajas (heads of leading <i>kshatriya</i> clans) performed rituals together and sat in assembly
How decisions were made	Discussion and debate in an assembly hall (<i>santhagara</i>). Where consensus failed, decisions were taken by vote — using counting sticks (shalakas), managed by an officer (shalaka-gahapaka) ★
Key examples	★ VAJJI (capital Vaishali) — the most famous; MALLA (Kusinara/Pava); Shakya (Kapilavastu — the Buddha's own clan); Licchavi (part of the Vajji confederacy); Koliya ; Kamboja
Famous members	Buddha was born into the Shakya gana ; Mahavira was born into the Vajji sangha (Jnatrika clan) ★★
How long they lasted	Roughly 1,000 years — some survived into the Gupta period (4th century CE) before being absorbed

⚖️ **Were they democracies? The honest answer**

This is where careless answers lose marks. Be precise.

✓ Genuinely republican features	✗ Genuinely undemocratic features
No single hereditary king	Only men of the leading <i>kshatriya</i> clans could be members
Decisions by debate and discussion	✗ WOMEN excluded
Voting where consensus failed (<i>shalakas</i>)	✗ DASAS (slaves) excluded
Rulers were many, not one	✗ KAMMAKARAS (landless labourers) excluded
A recorded procedure and officers to run it	The excluded were the majority of the population

🔗 **The formulation that earns marks:** *"The gana-sanghas were oligarchic republics rather than democracies in the modern sense — sovereignty rested with an assembly rather than a monarch, and decisions were taken by debate and vote, but participation was restricted to men of the dominant kshatriya clans, excluding women, labourers and slaves."*

That sentence gives you the credit for knowing the tradition *and* the credit for not romanticising it. **Both halves matter.**

🔗 **Where you'll actually use this (Polity/GS2):** whenever an answer needs to establish that India's democratic impulse is not merely a colonial import. The **Vajji sangha**, the **Buddhist sangha's own procedural rules** (quorum, motions, voting — Ch.6), and the South Indian **village assemblies** of the Chola *ur/sabha* (Ch.9) form a three-point indigenous lineage. Very effective in an introduction.

Why did they disappear?

- **Gupta-era absorption** and, before that, systematic conquest by the monarchies
- **Structural weakness:** consensus is slow; monarchy is fast. Under continuous military pressure, speed wins
- **Internal division was exploitable** — exactly what Vassakara did to the Vajjis
- Monarchies could mobilise **larger revenues and standing armies**

6 Panini and the Ashtadhyayi ★

Around the **5th–4th century BCE**, in **Gandhara** (Taxila region), **Panini** composed the **Ashtadhyayi** ("Eight Chapters") — a grammar of Sanskrit.

Aspect	Detail
What it is	A complete, formal grammar of Sanskrit in ~4,000 sutras (rules) across 8 chapters
Method	Extremely compressed, using a symbolic meta-language, abbreviations and ordered rules with exceptions
Significance	Widely regarded as the most complete and scientific grammar of any ancient language , and one of the great intellectual achievements of the ancient world
Why it matters here	Its existence tells us Sanskrit was being formalised and standardised in this period — an intellectual counterpart to the political standardisation happening around it



This one will genuinely delight you. The *Ashtadhyayi* is essentially **a formal generative grammar with a rule-ordering system and a meta-language** — written ~2,400 years before Chomsky. Panini's rules use techniques you'd recognise immediately: **recursion, an ordered rule-application priority (later/more specific rules override earlier/general ones — effectively exception handling), and a symbolic notation** (the *pratyahara* system compresses phoneme sets much like a bitmask). Computational linguists have shown the *Ashtadhyayi* is close to a **context-free grammar with context-sensitive extensions**, and it's frequently cited in the history of computer science and NLP.

Backus–Naur Form has a direct ancestor in 4th-century BCE Gandhara. That's not a stretch — it's a standard observation in the field.

7 Alexander's Invasion (326 BCE)

Aspect	Detail
Who	Alexander of Macedon (Greece), having conquered Egypt, Persia and Central Asia
When	Reached the north-west of the subcontinent in 326 BCE
Key battle	Battle of the Hydaspes (Jhelum) against King Porus (Puru) of the Paurava kingdom. Alexander won, but was so impressed by Porus's courage that he restored his kingdom ★
Why he turned back ★	His soldiers mutinied at the Beas (Vipas/Hyphasis) — exhausted after years of campaigning, and reportedly terrified by reports of the Nandas' vast army with thousands of war elephants waiting on the Ganga
Result	He never entered the Gangetic plain. He turned back and died in Babylon in 323 BCE

What it actually changed:

- **Politically: very little in India.** He held no Indian territory for long; his satrapies in the north-west collapsed within a generation
- **It created a power vacuum** in the north-west that **Chandragupta Maurya** promptly filled (Ch.7)
- **Indo-Greek contact** began — leading later to **Gandhara art** (Ch.10), Greek influence in coinage and astronomy, and the **Indo-Greek kingdoms** (e.g. **Menander/Milinda**, whose dialogue with the monk Nagasena became the *Milindapanha*)
- **Greek accounts** (Arrian, Plutarch, Strabo, Curtius) give us **valuable external descriptions** of Indian society — a *literary source* of the kind Chapter 1 taught you to value



The mature take for Mains: *"Alexander's invasion was militarily inconsequential for the subcontinent's interior but historically significant — it opened sustained Indo-Greek cultural and commercial contact and created the political vacuum in the north-west that enabled Mauryan expansion."*

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
16 Mahajanapadas + capitals ★★ ★	The matching table above. Prioritise: Magadha–Rajagriha/Pataliputra, Kosala–Shravasti, Vatsa–Kaushambi, Avanti–Ujjain, Vajji–Vaishali, Gandhara–Taxila, Kasi–Varanasi, Anga–Champa
Source of the list	Anguttara Nikaya (Buddhist text)
Only southern mahajanapada ★	Assaka/Ashmaka , on the Godavari
Bhaga ★★	1/6 of produce; king = shadbhagin
Vishti ★	Forced labour, one day a month
Ganas/Sanghas ★★ ★	Vajji (Vaishali) , Malla, Shakya, Licchavi, Koliya, Kamboja. Buddha = Shakya gana; Mahavira = Vajji sangha
Exclusions from ganas ★	Women, dasas, kammakaras
Voting	Shalakas (counting sticks)
Why Magadha won ★★	Iron ore, elephant forests, Ganga+Son rivers, Rajagriha & Pataliputra
Magadha ruler sequence ★	Bimbisara → Ajatasattu → Udayin → Shishunaga → Nandas
Bimbisara	Annexed Anga ; matrimonial alliances
Ajatasattu	Destroyed Vajji ; minister Vassakara ; <i>rathamusala, mahashilakantaka</i>
Udayin	Shifted capital to Pataliputra
Panini ★	Ashtadhyayi ; Gandhara; ~4,000 sutras
Alexander ★	326 BCE ; Porus at the Jhelum (Hydaspes) ; army mutinied at the Beas
Paddy transplantation	Higher yields; labour by dasas and kammakaras

Traps:

- "All sixteen mahajanapadas were monarchies" → **FALSE**. Vajji, Malla, Shakya, Kamboja etc. were **ganas/sanghas**
- "Ganas were democracies" → **Incomplete/misleading**. Oligarchic republics; women, dasas and kammakaras excluded
- "Bimbisara shifted the capital to Pataliputra" → **FALSE**. That was **Udayin**
- "Alexander conquered Magadha" → **FALSE**. He never reached the Ganga plain; his troops mutinied at the Beas
- "Bhaga was one-fourth" → **FALSE**. **One-sixth**

Mains

- **Polity/GS2 introductions:** the *gana-sangha* as India's indigenous republican tradition — with the exclusions honestly stated
- **State formation:** "Examine the factors that enabled Magadha to emerge as the paramount power among the mahajanapadas." Structure it as **geography (iron, elephants, rivers) + fortified capitals + ambitious rulers + institutional capacity (taxation, standing army)**
- **Economy:** taxation as the foundation of state capacity; the 1/6 *bhaga* as ancient India's fiscal base
- **Society:** the exploitation underlying agricultural surplus (dasas, kammakaras, *vishti*)

- **Art & Culture:** Panini's *Ashtadhyayi* as an intellectual achievement of world significance

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Jana	The people/tribe
Janapada	"Land where the <i>jana</i> sets its foot" — territory
Mahajanapada	A "great" janapada; 16 of them by ~600 BCE
Ashvamedha	Horse sacrifice asserting paramouncy
Rajasuya	Royal consecration ritual
Vajapeya	Chariot-race sacrifice conferring supremacy
Bhaga	"A share" — land tax of 1/6 of produce
Shadbhagin	"Taker of a sixth" — a title of the king
Bali	Voluntary offering (Rigvedic); later tribute
Kara	Tax
Vishti	Forced/unpaid labour, one day a month
Gana	A group with many members; a republic
Sangha	Assembly/organisation; also the Buddhist order (Ch.6)
Santhagara	Assembly hall of a gana
Shalaka	Counting stick used for voting
Dasa / Dasi	Enslaved man/woman
Kammakara	Landless wage labourer
Rathamusala	Scythed war chariot (Ajatasattu)
Mahashilakantaka	Stone-hurling catapult (Ajatasattu)
Ashtadhyayi	Panini's grammar of Sanskrit, in 8 chapters
Anguttara Nikaya	Buddhist text listing the 16 mahajanapadas
Transplantation	Growing paddy saplings in a nursery and replanting them in flooded fields

90-Second Recap

1. **Jana** (people) → **janapada** (territory) → **mahajanapada** (great state). **Land replaces cattle as wealth — because of iron.**
2. **Ashvamedha:** horse released for a year; those who let it pass submit, those who stop it fight. Then a grand sacrifice where other rajas serve in subordinate roles. **A ritual that tests and publicly records hierarchy.**
3. **16 Mahajanapadas** (listed in the **Anguttara Nikaya**). Know the capitals. **Assaka** is the only one south of the Vindhya.
4. **Four features of a mahajanapada:** fortified capital, standing army, regular taxation, officials.
5. **Taxes: bhaga = 1/6** of produce (king = *shadbhagin*); **vishti** = one day's free labour a month; herders pay in animals, traders on goods, hunters in forest produce.

6. **Agricultural surplus** came from the **iron ploughshare** and **paddy transplantation** — labour supplied by **dasas** and **kammakaras**.
 7. **Magadha won because of:** iron ore, elephant forests, the Ganga and Son, and two superb capitals (**Rajagriha**, then **Pataliputra**).
 8. **Rulers:** Bimbisara (annexed Anga) → Ajatasattu (destroyed Vajji via **Vassakara**) → Udayin (**capital to Pataliputra**) → Shishunaga (crushed Avanti) → **Nandas** → Mauryas.
 9. **Ganas/sanghas** were ruled by assemblies, not kings — **Vajji (Vaishali)** the most famous. Decisions by debate and **voting with shalakas**.
 10. **But:** women, dasas and kammakaras were **excluded**. **Oligarchic republics, not democracies**.
 11. **Buddha was born in the Shakya gana; Mahavira in the Vajji sangha** — the two great teachers of Ch.6 both come from republics, not monarchies.
 12. **Panini's Ashtadhyayi** — ~4,000 sutras, the most scientific ancient grammar, a formal generative grammar 2,400 years early.
 13. **Alexander, 326 BCE:** beat **Porus** at the **Jhelum**, restored his kingdom, then his army **mutinied at the Beas**. Militarily inconsequential inland, but it opened Indo-Greek contact and left a vacuum the Mauryas filled.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements about the gana-sanghas:
 1. Decisions were taken by discussion, and by vote where agreement failed.
 2. Women and slaves were excluded from the assembly.
 3. The Buddha was born into the Shakya gana. → *All three are correct.*
2. Which pairs are correctly matched?
 1. Vatsa — Kaushambi
 2. Avanti — Ujjain
 3. Gandhara — Rajapura → *1 and 2 only. Gandhara's capital was **Taxila**; Rajapura was **Kamboja's**.*
3. "Bhaga," the principal tax of the mahajanapada period, was — → *One-sixth of agricultural produce.*
4. The ruler who shifted the Magadhan capital from Rajagriha to Pataliputra was — → *Udayin.*
5. Consider the following:
 1. Assaka was the only mahajanapada situated south of the Vindhyas.
 2. The list of sixteen mahajanapadas appears in the Anguttara Nikaya.
 3. Alexander defeated the Nandas at the Battle of the Hydaspes. → *1 and 2 only. Hydaspes was against **Porus**; Alexander never fought the Nandas.*

Mains style

6. Examine the factors that enabled Magadha to emerge as the most powerful mahajanapada. **(250 words)**
7. "The gana-sanghas represent an indigenous republican tradition, but they were not democracies." Critically examine. **(250 words)**
8. Discuss the significance of Alexander's invasion for the subsequent history of the subcontinent. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- What does *janapada* literally mean, and why is that etymology important?

- Explain the Ashvamedha in four steps and say what it achieved politically.
 - Name four reasons Magadha won, and rank them.
 - Who was excluded from the gana assemblies, and why does that matter?
 - What did Vassakara do, and what does the episode illustrate?
 - Why is Panini's *Ashtadhyayi* remarkable?
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